

What else to watch: *Pinocchio* (1940) ■ *A Star Is Born* (1954) ■ *Return to Oz* (1985) ■ *Wild at Heart* (1990) ■ *Spirited Away* (2001, pp.296–97)

When Dorothy arrives in Oz, viewers see her open her eyes in faded, sepia-toned black and white, the frame crackling with the technical imperfections of the time. But as she opens the door and steps outside, they glimpse Oz and are overwhelmed with Technicolor. In 1939, when it was released, this would have been the very first time many audience members had seen a color movie. As the scene plays out, the director Victor Fleming is fully aware of this fact and he takes his

time to pan around Munchkinland, lingering on the extravagantly constructed set as its wave of hallucinatory colors hits the viewer from all angles. Then come the special effects, a musical number featuring hundreds of actors, and a showdown with the antagonist, the Wicked Witch of the West (the scenery and costume designers were encouraged to use as much color as possible to take full advantage of the Technicolor format). The whole time, viewers are adjusting to seeing color for the first time. This is a movie with the approach that “if less is more, then how much more must more

be,” dazzling with its no-expenses-spared production. In that sense, it is very much a forerunner of the modern blockbuster, with musical numbers in place of action set pieces.

Character-led story

Although the story is crafted to be the perfect vehicle to show off the wonderful new toys Hollywood had at its disposal, it is nonetheless deeply rooted in character and emotion. While we discover a new world, we do so through the prism of a distinct framing device. Whereas most adventure movies feature a group of »

When Dorothy first meets the Tin Man (Jack Haley), he is in desperate need of an oiling.

